



A SOLO DECK-BUILDER • 20–30 MINUTES

CINDER REACH

Colonize. Arm. Research. Hold the council. Outlast the fleet.

Prototype rules • one governor • ten cycles

The mandate

You are the governor of Ark-9, dropped into an uncharted system with a dying beacon and ten cycles before the Silent Fleet arrives. Your deck is the colony: settlers, ships, labs, and decrees. Every cycle you either buy power, survey a world, or purge a problem. Then the system answers.

The game is built to finish in 20–30 minutes. One main action per cycle. Supply does not bank. The crisis resolves while your cards are still on the table, so you always know why you were punished.

WHAT A CYCLE IS ASKING

- Colonization — claim worlds, take Outposts, and plant enough sites that the beacon can lock.
- Exploration — survey for a cheaper look, then decide whether the same world is worth settling.
- Military conflict — Intercept and Gunships hold the Fleet track. At 5, the invasion resolves.
- Political strife — Decrees keep Stability up and scrap Unrest. Neglect the council and your deck clogs.
- Technological advancement — Labs discount buys and switch on the Defense Grid, the only thing that can survive a landing.
- Alien invasion — the Silent Fleet is a track, not a deck to fight card-by-card. It only cares whether you showed up armed.

WHAT YOU NEED

- These rules, a governor sheet (last page), and about 50 sleeved cards or paper slips.
- Tokens for Supply — coins or a d12. Unspent Supply is lost at cleanup.
- A pencil. Tracks live on the sheet, not on cards.

TRACKS

- Cycle, 1 to 10. Advance at cleanup. The game ends after cycle 10 unless you already won or lost.
- Stability, 0 to 8. Start at 5. At 0, the council collapses and you lose immediately.
- Fleet, 0 to 5. Start at 0. At 5, resolve Invasion (see Win and loss).
- Colonies, 0 to 4. Mark one each time you colonize and take an Outpost.
- Defense Grid, off until you buy the card or colonize Black Relay. It is the Hold condition.

SETUP

- Sheet: Cycle 1, Stability 5, Fleet 0, Colonies 0, Defense Grid off.
- Starter deck: 5 Colonist, 3 Militia, 2 Charter. Shuffle. Draw 5. Outposts (4) and Unrest (8) stay in side piles.
- Shuffle the 23-card market. Deal 4 face up in a row — the Reach. Empty slots refill from this deck only.
- Shuffle the 6 worlds. Deal 3 face up — the System. The other 3 are the Deep, face down.
- Shuffle the 10 crises face down. Do not reshuffle them. If the deck ever runs out, Fleet +1 instead of drawing.

A cycle

1. PLAY

Play any number of cards from your hand, in any order. Gain the Supply printed on them and resolve their text. Tags on played cards are in play for the crisis. Unplayed cards stay in hand until cleanup.

2. ONE MAIN ACTION

- Buy. Pay the cost of one Reach card. Put it on your discard. Refill that slot. Labs and Skiffs can discount this buy (see Keywords).
- Survey. Pay one face-up world's survey cost. Resolve its survey line. You may then colonize that same world by paying its colony cost. Take an Outpost onto your discard, mark a Colony, remove the world, and refill from the Deep. If the Deep is empty, the slot stays empty.
- Purge. Scrap one card from your hand (return it to its supply, or set a market card aside). You do not buy or survey.

You may not buy and survey in the same cycle. Colonizing is part of the survey action, not a second action.

3. CRISIS

Draw one crisis and resolve it. Unless-clauses look only at cards in play this cycle. Intercept cancels the first Fleet +1 on that crisis and nothing else. Then discard the crisis from the game.

4. CLEANUP

- Discard every card still in play and in hand.
- Lose all unspent Supply.
- Draw 5. If the deck empties mid-draw, shuffle the discard into a new deck and continue. Do not shuffle scrapped cards back in.
- Advance the Cycle marker. If it moves past 10, score the mandate.

WIN AND LOSS

- Collapse. Stability 0 at any moment. Lose.
- Invasion. The instant Fleet hits 5: if you have 2 or more Colonies and Defense Grid is on, you Hold — Fleet stays at 5, further Fleet advances are ignored, and you play on. Otherwise you lose.
- Beacon lock. The instant you reach 4 Colonies while Fleet is 4 or less, you win.
- Mandate. After cycle 10, if you have not lost and you have at least 2 Colonies, you win.

SCORE, IF YOU WANT A NUMBER

3 per Colony, 1 per Stability remaining, 2 if Fleet is 0 or 1, 2 if Defense Grid is on, 1 per Lab card in your deck, hand, and discard, minus 1 per Unrest still in your cards. A clean mandate is about 12. A beacon lock with the Grid on is the prestige run.

DIFFICULTY

- Prospect. Stability starts at 6.
- Mandate. As written. This is the intended 25-minute game.
- Silent. Fleet starts at 1, and cycle 1's crisis is always Silent Ping, shuffled back only if you want a longer cruel deck — otherwise resolve it and discard it, then shuffle the rest.

Keywords

- Supply. Spent the cycle you gain it. Never banks.
- Scrap. Remove the card from the game. Starters return to the box. Unrest returns to its pile. Market cards are set aside, not returned to the Reach.
- Intercept. Cancel the first Fleet +1 from this cycle's crisis. A second advance on the same crisis still happens.
- Tags. COLONY, SURVEY, FLEET, DECREE, LAB. A crisis counts tags in play, not cards left in the deck.
- Discount. A 1-less effect applies to the next buy this cycle, once. It cannot reduce a cost below 0.

WORLDS

Rust Mesa

Survey 2: +2 Supply. Colonize 5: Outpost, Stability +1.

Glass Sea

Survey 1: draw 1. Colonize 4: Outpost.

Pale Garden

Survey 2: Stability +1. Colonize 4: Outpost, scrap an Unrest from hand or discard.

Red Choir

Survey 2: Fleet -1. Colonize 5: Outpost.

Vault Orbit

Survey 3: the next Lab you buy this game costs 2 less. Colonize 6: Outpost, draw 1.

Black Relay

Survey 3: look at the top 2 crises, put one on the bottom and one back on top. Colonize 6: Outpost, and either switch Defense Grid on or Fleet -1.

CRISES

Ration Riot — Unless 2 COLONY tags are in play: Stability -1, and put 1 Unrest on your discard.

Admiralty Demand — Unless a FLEET tag is in play: Fleet +1.

Consortium Embargo — Unless a DECREE tag is in play: Stability -1.

Silent Ping — Fleet +1.

Council Fracture — Unless a DECREE tag is in play: Stability -1, and put 1 Unrest on your discard.

Harvest Blight — Scrap a card from your hand, or Stability -1.

Probe Swarm — Unless a FLEET tag is in play: Fleet +1. If Fleet is already 3 or more after this, also Stability -1.

Refugee Wave — Put 1 Unrest on your discard, then draw 1.

Deep Signal — Look at the top crisis and put it back. Then Fleet +1, unless you scrap a card from hand.

Beacon Flicker — If you have fewer than 2 Colonies: Stability -1 and Fleet +1.

The deck

Copy counts are the whole prototype. Write the tag in a corner so crises are readable at a glance.



Habitat



Gunship



Silent probe

STARTER AND SIDE PILES

Colonist ×5

Militia ×3

Charter ×2

Outpost ×4

Unrest ×8

COLONY · +1 Supply

FLEET · +1 Supply

DECREE · +2 Supply

COLONY · +2 Supply. Gained only by colonizing. Side pile.

No tag · +0. Dead weight. Side pile. Enters via crises.

MARKET — THE REACH

Survey Skiff ×3

Habitat Ring ×3

Decree ×3

Embassy ×2

Militia Wing ×2

Field Lab ×2

Foundry ×2

Listener Array ×1

Gene Vault ×1

Gunship ×2

Arcology ×1

Defense Grid ×1

2 · SURVEY · +2 Supply. The survey you make this cycle costs 1 less.

3 · COLONY · +2 Supply.

2 · DECREE · +1 Supply. Scrap an Unrest from hand, play, or discard.

3 · DECREE · +2 Supply. Stability +1.

3 · FLEET · +2 Supply. Intercept.

4 · LAB · +2 Supply. The next card you buy this cycle costs 1 less.

4 · COLONY · +3 Supply.

4 · SURVEY · +2 Supply. Look at the top crisis; you may bottom it.

5 · LAB · +2 Supply. Draw 1.

5 · FLEET · +3 Supply. Fleet -1. Intercept.

6 · COLONY · +4 Supply. Stability +1.

6 · LAB · +2 Supply. Switch Defense Grid on. Intercept.

A FIRST CYCLE, PLAYED OUT

Hand: Colonist, Colonist, Militia, Charter, and a Survey Skiff bought last cycle. Play all five. Supply is 7. Tags in play: COLONY, COLONY, FLEET, DECREE, SURVEY. Survey Glass Sea for 0, because the Skiff discounts it. Draw 1.

Colonize Glass Sea for 4. Take an Outpost onto the discard. Colonies = 1. Three Supply vanishes at cleanup. Crisis is

Silent Ping: Fleet becomes 1. Starter Militia does not Intercept — only Militia Wing, Gunship, and Defense Grid do. Draw 5. Cycle 2.

Governor sheet

One run. Circle the current value. Standard start: Cycle 1, Stability 5, Fleet 0, Colonies 0, Grid off.

Cycle

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

end after 10

Stability

0

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

start 5 · lose at 0

Fleet

0

1

2

3

4

5

start 0 · invasion at 5

Colonies

0

1

2

3

4

win at 4 if Fleet ≤ 4

- ☐ **Defense Grid on** Bought, or taken when colonizing Black Relay.
- ☐ **Vault discount armed** Next Lab costs 2 less. Cross off when used.

RUN NOTES

QUICK REFERENCE

- Play cards. One action: buy, survey (and maybe colonize), or purge. Crisis. Discard, drop Supply, draw 5, cycle +1.
- Hold the landing only with 2 Colonies and the Grid. Otherwise Fleet 5 is a loss.
- Two Colonies by cycle 10 is a win. Four Colonies early is a beacon lock.
- If a rule and a card disagree, the card wins. If two discounts apply, they stack, minimum 0.

Design note. Ten cycles, one action, no banked Supply. That is the whole clock. A first run that ignores Decrees will drown in Unrest around cycle 6. A first run that only buys Gunships will miss the colony count. The intended tension is refusing a perfect card because the track you are not feeding is the one about to break.